

Media Aesthetics: Text

Paper # 1

>. Check list

Following is a checklist that outlines the structure of the argument. Your paper should follow this structure in order to construct a good argument.

Introduction

- Topic: is the topic specific and clearly presented to the reader?
- Question: does the paper pose a clear and specific question about the topic?
- Conceptual keywords: are they defined clearly? are they integrated effectively with the topic?
- Main Claim: does the claim effectively answer the question of the paper? is it an arguable claim? does it produce an insightful (non-obvious) interpretation of the image?

Body paragraphs

- Subclaims: does the subclaim develop the main claim and extend it?
- Microanalysis (close reading of the image): does the paper perform good microanalysis that pays attention to the specific details of the image?
- Evidence: is the evidence convincing? is it sufficiently presented?
- Reasons: is the argument supported by good reasoning?

>. Assignment

For your paper assignment, you are asked to write a **900-word essay**. **You may combine up to two media objects** (and image and a text or two images) for your essay (although one media object is sufficient). Examples include works on Canvas by Magritte, Kosuth, Zelinskie, Duchamp, Jenny Holzer, John Baldessari, Bruce Nauman, and so on. Alternatively, you may combine an image and a text (e.g. “Purloined Letter” and a Sherlock episode, or Kac’s “Genesis” with the Biblical one in the Canvas folder Wk.II., etc).

Here is a list of items to consider (this is not a restrictive or exhaustive list. Any example we discussed in class, or that appears in the readings, or is in the Canvas folders, is also an option for your essay):

- Poe: "The Purloined Letter"
- Sherlock Holmes BBC series (you may write on only **ONE** episode in the series, preferably the first one we discussed in class, "A Study in Pink").
- F. Laroui: "Dislocation"
- Duchamp's "Fountain" and/or shovel.
- Ashley Zelinskie's "One and One Chair"
- Bruce Nauman's neon art signs (see Week.1. slides)
- Additional Artworks folder on Canvas which includes works by Holzer, Kruger, Baldessari, among others. Here are some suggested Baldessari works:
"I will not make anymore boring art" <https://www.moma.org/collection/works/59546>
"What is Painting?" <https://www.moma.org/collection/works/79910>
- Eduardo Kac's "Genesis". You can combine it with the Biblical excerpts in the Wk II folder from "Genesis" and think about the relationship between the two works.
<http://www.ekac.org/geneseries.html>
<http://www.ekac.org/biblemorse.html>
- Wallace Stevens: "Anecdote of the Jar"

Keywords: You may use up to six keywords for your paper, from **one or two sources** (for e.g. Saussure, Chandler on Peirce, Wellbery on "Systems", or Barthes on authorship etc). However, you are not required to use two sources. One source is enough if that helps you to produce a good interpretation of your chosen media example.

A few pointers:

It is a good idea to limit your keyword selection initially to a couple of keywords. Second, whatever keywords you use in your essay should be **defined** and presented to the reader with the proper **quotes and citations** from your chosen source(s). Third, the keywords you will use (as well as your source) should be presented in your **introduction**. However, this does not mean that you need to exhaustively define your keywords in the introduction, only that you are to provide

your reader with an initial definition of your keyword(s). You can amplify the keyword(s), extend and develop them in the body paragraphs. Note that in defining your keywords you are to avoid using lengthy blockquotes. This is because you are acting as a guide to your reader (explaining, summarizing, interpreting), giving him or her information about the keyword(s) from the text. And you also need to tell your reader how you are going to apply the term(s) to your object of analysis (**relevance** of the keyword(s) to your image or text).

Writing: A Multi-Step Process

A main goal of the assignment is to acquire the skill of defining your own topic, question, and thesis for the paper. A good way to do this is to approach the assignment as a multi-step process, beginning with defining a **topic**. It may take you a while to settle on a topic of interest; this is fine. Keep thinking and writing down your ideas until the topic becomes well-defined. The second step is defining the **question or problem** with which you will engage in the paper. The third step is to generate a **thesis** as an answer or argument that advances your solution for the question/problem that you posed in relation to your paper topic.

If you approach the process of generating a paper topic and question in the above-suggested manner, you will both write an essay about something which you find interesting, and around which you have defined a problem, which you would like to communicate to other people – your readers. Your thesis shows that your proposed answer to the problem you have defined for the reader is convincing, robust, and interesting. And the rest of the paper – the **body paragraphs** – unpack for the reader your main thesis and elaborate on it, supporting it with **evidence**, and exploring it in detail through **close reading** of your chosen text and/or image.

In following the above steps, your goal is ultimately to present your reader with a convincing and interesting (i.e. not readily obvious) series of points and observations about your chosen text.

Formatting:

Your paper should include a **title**, your **name**, use a **12-size font**, be **double-spaced** and **page-numbered**. Also, do not forget to include page numbers when citing texts, and to proof-read your paper for any typos or grammatical errors.

>. Suggested topics

Here is a list of topics to choose from for your paper. The topics and keywords below, and questions, are meant as helpful guides for you to generate your paper. **You do not necessarily have to address all the questions listed for a given topic; choose the ones that most fit your topic and key concepts** (theoretical definitions from the readings).

Also, you may construct your own paper topic (you do not need to adhere to the topics listed below). You have a lot the freedom and flexibility to decide what works best for your paper.

-“Purloined Letter”: **Symbolic Media and the Crime Game.** Write an essay about “The Purloined Letter” in which you discuss the letter as a symbolic medium (also called “symbolically generalized media”) that constructs the crime system we see in the story. Take into consideration the way that the circulation of the letter creates also different modes of observation in relation to the letter and in relation to how it was stolen.

-Keywords: Wellbery “Systems” and/or Wolfe “Language”. Alternatively, you can combine one of the preceding essays with Chandler on semiotics (for instance Peirce on iconic/indexical/symbolic signs).

Questions to consider: select one or more questions from the list below for your essay.

-the letter is written in language, which is a symbolic medium. **Consider the circulation of the letter as a symbolic medium** which acquires currency, namely power, in the act of circulation by theft (the Minister purloining the letter from the Queen).

-second, think about **how the circulation of the letter constructs a system**. What type of communication system is created by the circulation of the letter? What are the boundaries of this system?

-what do you make of the probabilistic nature of the communication in the system? Where or when do we see characters trying to figure out the communication in the system and struggling with the probabilistic nature of the communication? You may want to take into consideration that the signs in the system require the characters to often make inferences from the signs they observe. How do Dupin and the prefect of police differ in the inferences they make based on the signs they observe?

-also, what modes of observation do the two characters adopt in relation to the crime? Think about which characters perform direct-experience observation (first-order observation) of the crime scene, and which characters perform second-order observation (observing other observers).

-think about the stealing and the concealing of the letter as game-like activities. And consider how the game-like character of the system is something completely missed by the perfect of police. In thinking about the crime as a game system, keep in mind that games also operate by observing the moves other players make, and also observing how the other players think about the moves they are making (in other words, take into account that the game is a device that allows Dupin to see that there are first-order and second-order observations, and to perform those observations, in the crime system).

-Sherlock: “A Study in Pink”. Write an essay in which you consider the relationship between Watson and Sherlock as representative, respectively, of the systems of consciousness and communication. Explore in your essay the relationship between each system and signs (whether

Peirce or Saussure, or both, in Chandler's *Semiotics*). Consider what types of signs the two characters are most adept at interpreting (in which context do these signs occur, in other words, in which systems of communication). And consider also, and in addition, the relationship between Sherlock and Watson as a relationship mediated by language. As the essay on "Systems" argues, and also the essay by Wolfe, the systems of mind and communication do not co-exist peacefully, but mutually irritate one another, since each is an environment for the other system, producing noise for it, and intruding upon its ability to operate smoothly. How does the episode represent this mutually divisive relationship between consciousness and communication (represented by Sherlock and Watson)? But also, how do these two systems manage to link up and cooperate through structural coupling (language mediating between the systems of consciousness and communication)?

-Art and Life: Eduardo Kac. For this paper topic, think about life and communication as autopoietic systems in Eduardo Kac's work. Kac (pronounced Katz) is the founder of Bioart, a movement of art which is influenced by conceptual art (with its forerunners like Duchamp and Magritte). Like Magritte, Kac draws attention to language, text, and the conceptual realm of ideas in his art. But where Magritte links text and image, Kac links text and life. Recall that, as per the "Systems" essay, communication and life (as well as consciousness) are autopoietic systems (systems which reproduce and remake themselves, and adapt in the process to their environments). Furthermore, and as the essays by Wellbery on "Systems" and by Wolfe on "Language" indicate, the symbolic medium of language mediates between consciousness and communication. With this in mind, how does Kac's work make language mediate between the autopoietic systems of communication and life. How would you read or interpret the way language functions as a symbolic medium in his work that interfaces life and mind, instead of consciousness and communication only?

-This is not "X": Sign and Self-Reference. Write a paper in which you examine a text and an image (or instead of the text, another image) which display an object to the viewer discrepant with its own representation (the discrepancy arising from the way the symbolic medium of language is used in the work). The primary example is of course Magritte's "Treachery of Images", with its declaration "this is not a pipe". Read, along these lines, Poe's "Purloined Letter", paying attention to the mode of concealment of the letter by the Minister. Recall that, in the story, the Minister is also a poet, meaning he is an artist, someone who is aesthetically inclined. What kind of artist is the Minister? Consider that the manner by which he conceals the letter is aesthetic; he hides the letter in plain sight, as if to say "this is not the letter". To hide something in plain sight is what works of art do. They show us images, texts, etc, which are right in front of our eyes, but which pose an interpretive challenge for the observer (we struggle to link the signs of the aesthetic object together to arrive at an interpretation). A key question, in relation to the letter, based on the foregoing is: what is the self-reference at work in the story through the letter as a symbolic medium? Compare this self-reference with Magritte's "this is not a pipe", where the self-reference points to the signs composing the work (the symbolic signs of language,

and the iconic sign of the image – the pipe). By the same token, what is the self-reference that the letter generates as a symbolic medium? How is it different from Magritte's work? You may want to think about the letter as a symbolic medium that appears in a text, which is after all a different medium than a painting like Magritte's.

Alternatively, but along these lines, examine works by Jenny Holzer or John Baldessari, which represent texts which are discrepant with their representations, i.e. they show the viewer something akin to "this is not a pipe". Consider for instance Holzer's "Truisms" (Wk.II folder on Canvas under "Additional Works"). How do these truisms function in a manner that declares "these are not truisms". Take into consideration that the work is displayed in an art museum (the Guggenheim), and consider also the type of system in which the artwork is displayed, and how the text relates to that system. Truisms are of course ready-made communicative expressions. In other words, linguistic ready-mades are taken from systems of communication. If so, you may want to identify the system of communication to which these truisms belong. What is the binary code, for instance, of the original system, and does the binary code change when these truisms are made into an artistic work displayed in a building for observers to look at?

Or, from a different angle, you may also want to think about how these truisms compare with Duchamp's "Fountain", the prime example of the ready-made. While Duchamp's ready-made is an object, a utilitarian entity, the material of which Holzer's ready-made is composed is symbolic: language itself. How does language function here as communication that is re-entered into the art system? What does it acquire in this system beyond the ordinary uses it has in ordinary social communication and other social systems? To address this question, think about the binary code of the system. Recall that the binary code of the art system is "art/not-art", or, "aesthetic/non-aesthetic". If the "fountain" makes reference to the code (it is self-referential with respect to it, because it focuses on the very code of the system, highlighting that the code is the binary between aesthetic/non-aesthetic), then how does Holzer's work address the binary code of the artistic system? Finally, think about the way the work creates a boundary around itself distinct from its environment. What is the relationship between the work and the environment (the museum or building where it is displayed)?

-“Anecdote of the Jar”: Produce a reading of Wallace Stevens' "Anecdote of the Jar" by focusing on the jar as a sign (a symbolic sign), and the jar as an aesthetic object represented by the poem. Is the jar a self-referential sign? And if so, what does it refer to? Consider in this context Saussure's theory, which claims that semantic meaning in language is established through pure differences between the signs related together in language. How does the sign "jar" function here in relation to the differential field of other symbolic signs (the words) in the poem? Also, what is the binary code that the poem revolves around? Moreover, what type of system does the poem create for us as readers or allow us to see at work? In answering this question, think about the fact that nature is an autopoietic system (especially living nature), while the jar is a non-autopoietic (because non-reproducing) object. What do you make of this juxtaposition

between autopoietic and non-autopoietic elements in the poem (and between the non-adaptive jar and the adaptive nature surrounding it)?

You may, as an alternative, or supplement to the above, consider comparing “Anecdote of the Jar” with another work, for instance by Jenny Holzer, or John Baldessari, or Duchamp, or Magritte. If you choose this comparative option, your paper should be attentive to the differences between the media you are examining. Your argument should address the medium in which the signs are displayed as a central component of your essay. Refer, for your keywords, to the medium/form distinction in the “Systems” essay by Wellbery.

Good luck!